

01

KNITTED COTTON T-SHIRTS

Bahrain Import Study 2021-2025

Direct Import Feasibility

Building a data-driven case for sourcing cotton garments directly, without a distributor middleman.

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Data Science Bootcamp - Bahrain 2026 | Project 2: Exploratory Data Analysis



Introduction & Background

Bahrain is a small, trade-dependent Gulf economy that imports most of its consumer goods, including textiles.

The Bahrain Open Data Portal publishes monthly, transaction-level import records - partner country, commodity, value, weight, and quantity - spanning 2021 to 2025.

Knitted T-Shirts and Other Vests of Cotton stood out as the highest-volume commodity in the dataset, sourced from 133 different countries - an ideal case for comparing import costs across suppliers.

1.6M+

cleaned import
transactions

5 yrs

of monthly import
history (2021-2025)

133

countries supplying
this commodity

? The Problem

A local clothing business wants to stop buying from expensive distributors and import products directly.

To do that, they need answers to three questions:

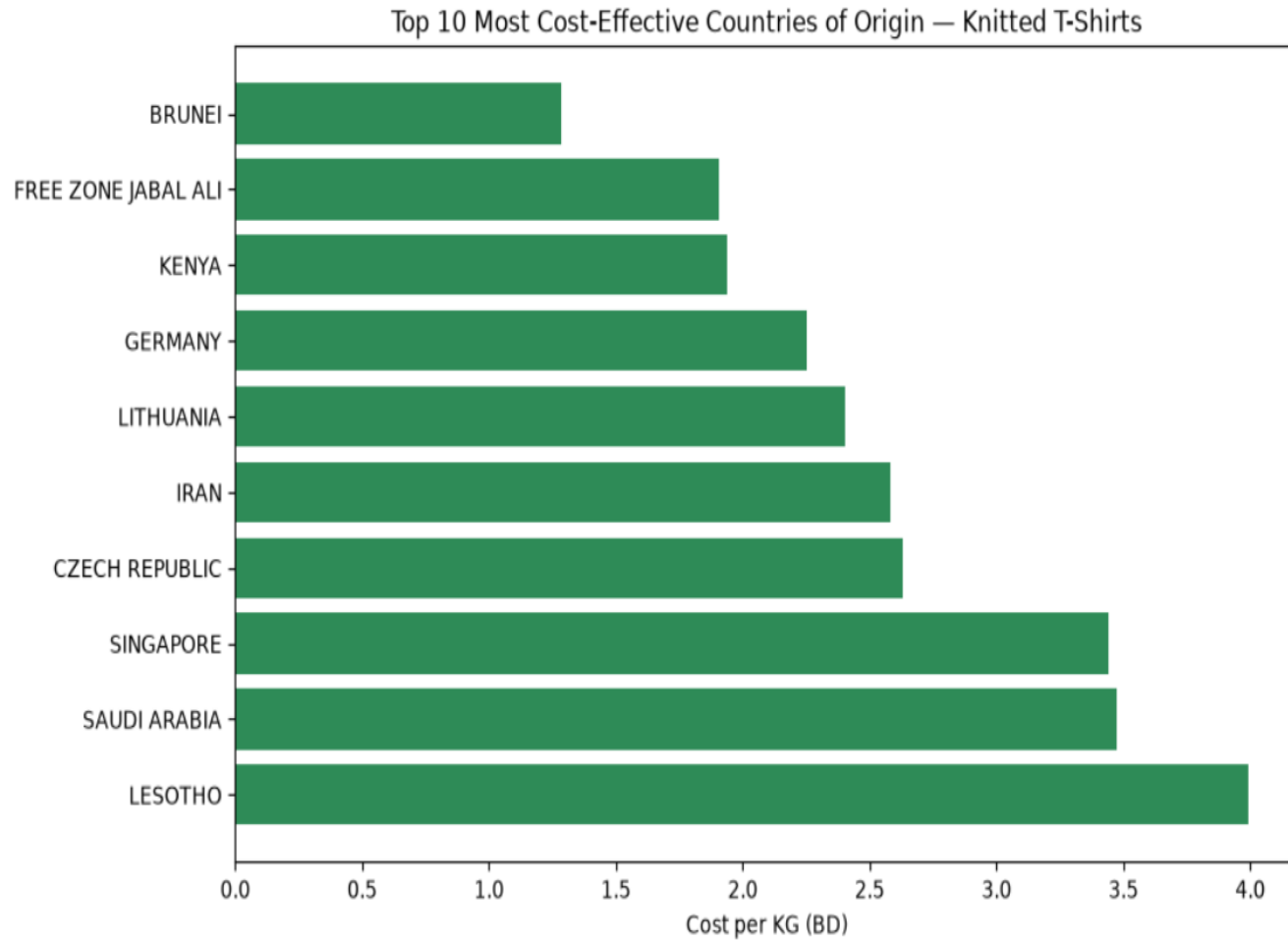
1 Which countries offer the best prices?

2 Does demand change during the year?

3 When is the best time to import?

1

Q1: Which Countries Offer the Best Prices?



KEY INSIGHT

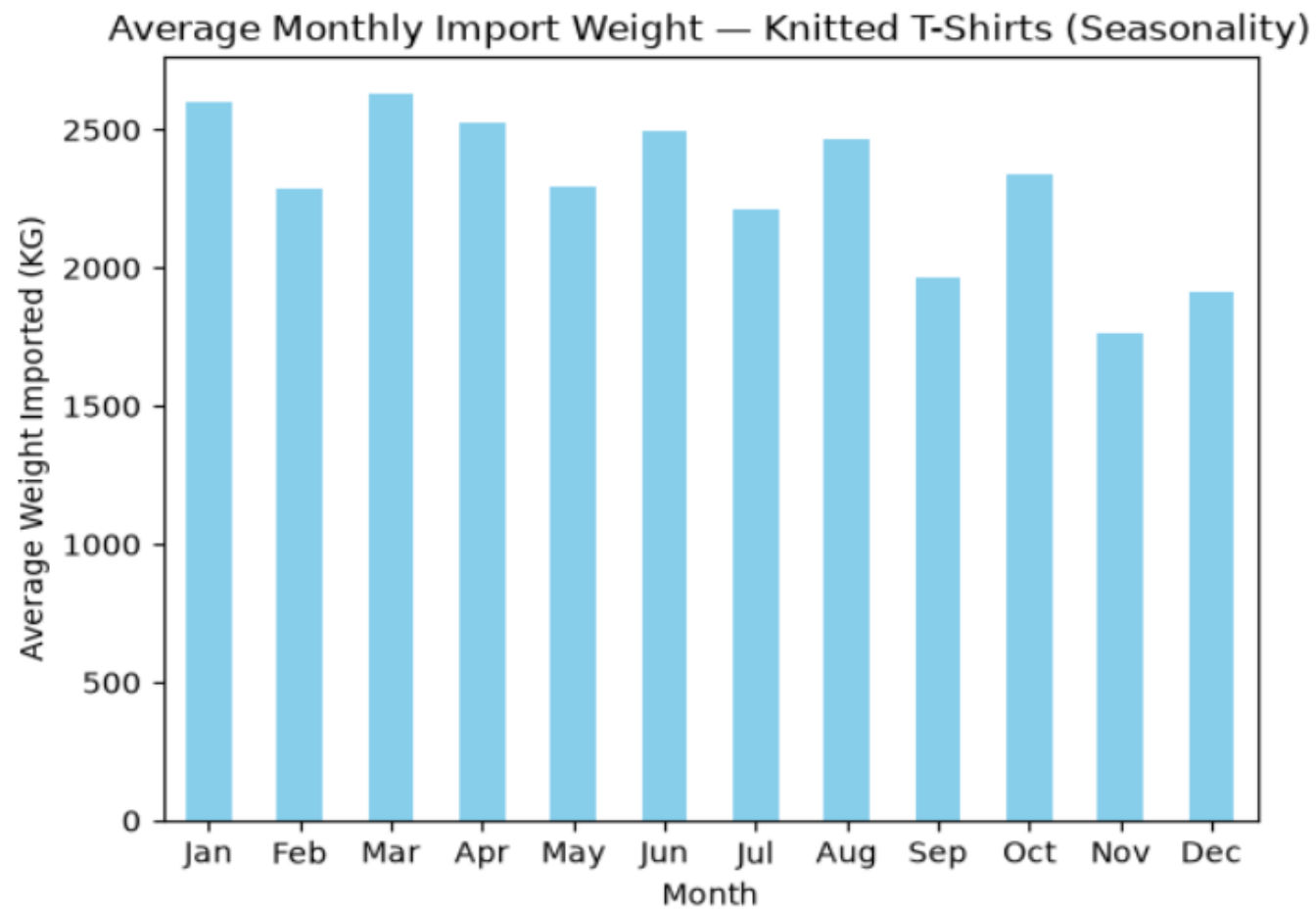
Brunei offers the lowest cost at 1.28 BD/KG - the Most Cost-Effective.

Free Zone Jabal Ali and Kenya follow closely as strong secondary options.

Lesotho, at 4.0 BD/KG, costs over 3x more than Brunei.

2

Q2: Does Demand Change During the Year?



KEY INSIGHT

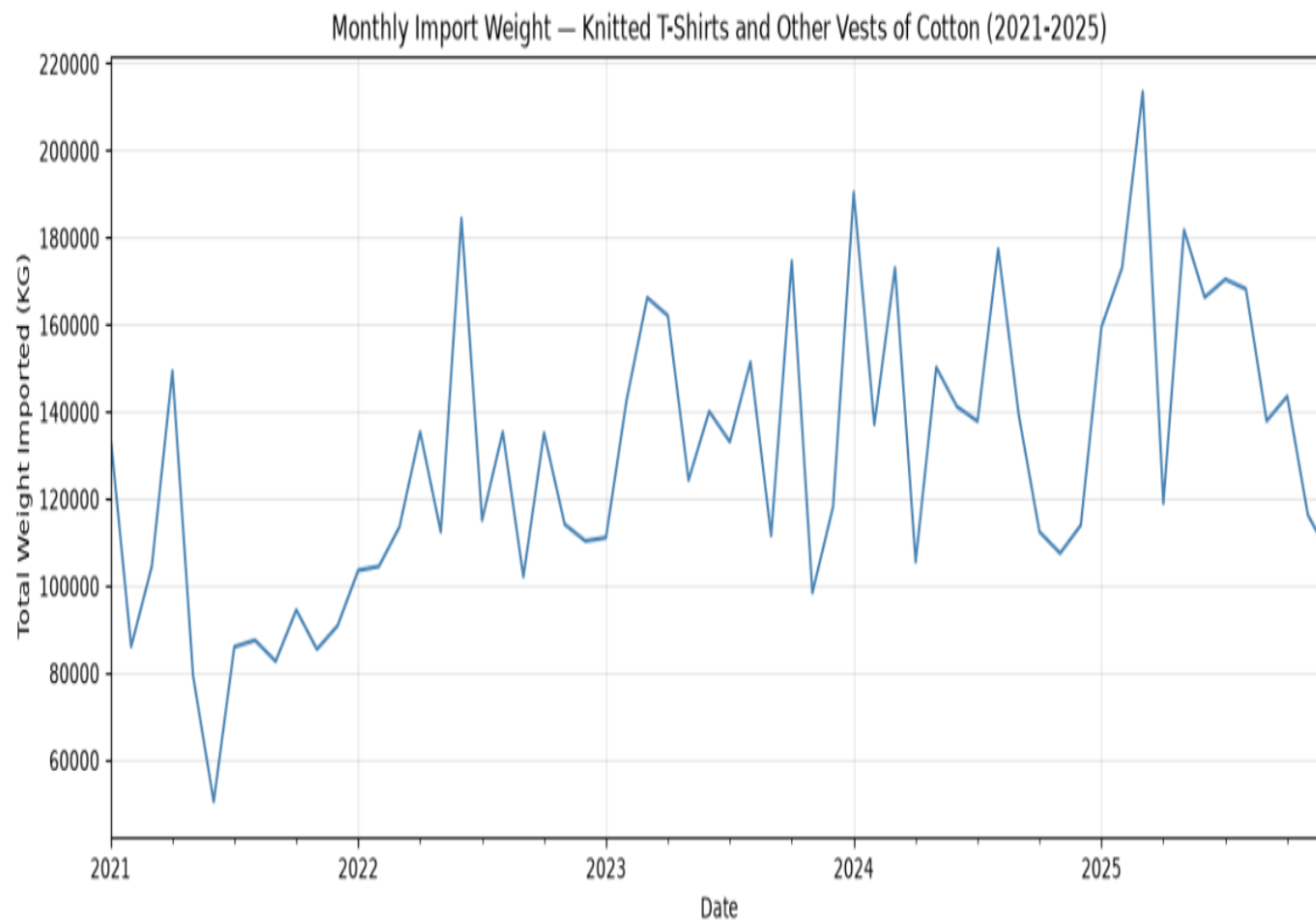
Yes - demand is strongest January through August, peaking in March (2,630 KG avg).

Demand steadily drops from September, bottoming out in November (1,760 KG avg).

This pattern repeats every year, independent of overall growth.

3

Q3: When Is the Best Time to Import?



KEY INSIGHT

Overall volume has grown steadily - from 80,000 KG/month in 2021 to peaks over 200,000 KG by 2024-2025.

Combined with seasonality, the best time to place large orders is before the March demand peak.

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Summary of Findings

Best Prices

Brunei, Free Zone Jabal Ali, and Kenya are the most cost-effective sources - up to 3x cheaper than the priciest reliable supplier.

Demand Changes

Import demand is clearly seasonal, peaking in March and bottoming out in November, every year.

R Recommendations & Next Steps

1 Prioritize Brunei & Kenya

Establish direct-import relationships with the two most cost-effective, reliable suppliers.

2 Order Before March

Place larger bulk orders ahead of the identified seasonal demand peak.

3 Diversify Across 2-3 Countries

Avoid single-supplier dependency by sourcing from multiple cost-effective origins.

4 Check Prices Regularly

Prices shift over time, so review this cost ranking every few months to make sure you're still buying from the cheapest countries.